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Widow’s clothing

6.15 Widow’s clothing

References:

Hebrew בֶּגֶד, אַלְמָנוּת (bigdey ’almanuth) GEN 38:14, GEN 38:19

Greek ἱμάτιον, χηρεύσις (himatia tēs chēreuseōs) JDT 8:5, JDT 10:3

Greek στολή, χήρευσις (stolē chēreuseōs) JDT 16:7

Description and usage:

The widow’s clothing was a robe or dress with a special design or color to indicate that her husband had died. The exact nature of the widow’s clothing of Judith is unknown, although it is possible that at least part of what she wore was made of sackcloth (see 4.8.5 Sackcloth, mourning clothes<REALIA:4.8.5>).

Translation:

In many cultures a widow can be identified by her dress or some other external sign. In some places she will wear black or white for a certain period of time or even for the rest of her life. Where such a custom exists, a translation may use the word for the clothing or other symbol that identifies the widow.

DEU 24:17 mentions the “cloak of a widow.” This does not seem to be a garment peculiar to widows only but a normal cloak worn by everyone (see 6.2 Outer garment, cloak, mantle, robe<REALIA:6.2>). Because of the protected status of widows in Israelite society, items of clothing were not to be taken from them. Similarly, in ACT 9:39 there is no reason to assume that the clothes made by Dorcas were special “widows’ clothing,” although they were certainly women’s clothes.